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A defining tournament sees **R. Vaishali** step out of the shadows and Javokhir Sindarov stamp his authority before the World Championship.

Pranay Rajiv

pranay.rajiv@thehindu.co.in

For a long time, Indian chess Grandmaster R. Vaishali existed in the shadows, and thrived there.

First, it was the presence of her brother, R. Praggnanandhaa, who garnered the lion's share of attention owing to his prodigious talent.

Even in Indian women's chess, Vaishali was never the centrepiece. The more experienced Koneru Humpy and D. Harika remained the country's flagbearers.

Following Divya Deshmukh's swift ascent after her FIDE World Cup 2025 triumph, Vaishali was pushed further into the background.

But over a fortnight in Cyprus, battling through an elite field, Vaishali stepped out of the shadows and into the spotlight reserved for the elite.

By becoming the first Indian to win the FIDE Women's Candidates title, the 24-year-old qualified for the World Championship final against China's Ju Wenjun later this year.

Vaishali entered the Candidates as the lowest-ranked player in the women's section. Her performance in the opening rounds reflected that: she began with four draws.

A defeat to Zhu Jiner in Round 5 triggered a shift in approach. From Round 6 to 11, Vaishali won four games and drew the other two to surge into the lead.

Triumphant moment: R. Vaishali won the 2026 Women's Candidates, with Bibisara Assaubayeva (left) finishing second and Zhu Jiner taking third place.

Pics: FIDE / NIKI RIGA